

its release) is forcing the team behind Internet Explorer to sit up and defend their creation (<http://blogs.msdn.com/ie/>). The next version of IE will need to be more compliant to standards or further lose market share.

Standards are coming.

EVENT > SENDER ID AND DOMAIN KEYS

Fighting Spam

A report, released May 2004, stated that 80 per cent of all e-mails in the United States were spam. The US, incidentally is the largest exporter of spam e-mail. A related article by the author of *Faster*, James Gleick threw some startling figures: 10 billion spam e-mails are sent every day; 30 billion are expected by 2005. You have been spammed; you know it isn't pretty.

Spam is largely driven by spoofed e-mail addresses. How many times have you received a spam from a friend's or a colleague's mail address? By spoofing an ID from your list of contacts, a modern-day spam bypasses filters you may employ—be it a blacklist, a whitelist or a combination. The idea then is to certify a user as genuine and his/her mail as authentic... which is where anti-spam identification systems step in.

Sender ID was one such system, spearheaded by Microsoft. It was however rejected by the Internet Engineering Task Force, the Apache group and AOL. The concern was over the fact that Microsoft held key patents on Sender ID and its licensing terms weren't Open Source friendly. In the current climate of software IPs and SCO-style litigations, the industry felt it wise to step away from the proposal. Microsoft revised the same, narrowing the scope of the patents and offering backwards compatibility with existing systems. The revision has seen AOL sign-on to Sender ID, while Apache is still on the fence.

Yahoo! meanwhile has proposed a system based on a public/private key encryption system called Domain Keys, this system has at least one major backer—Google in addition to other e-mail service providers. The Web is thus fragmented on an effective anti-spam method. Meanwhile, the mails keep flooding in...

PEOPLE > KRISHNA BHARAT, PRINCIPAL SCIENTIST, GOOGLE INC.

Father of Google News

Krishna Bharat is a Principal Scientist at Google Inc. 2004 saw him pack his bags and move to Bangalore as one of a triumvirate, heading a recently unveiled Google research and development centre there.

Krishna is of course the creator of Google News, the online news aggregator which has empowered people, ruffled the feathers of journalists and bagged a Webby Award. Google News is a content aggregator—Web spiders running on algorithm-powered legs, scour the Internet and some 4,500 news sources and gather relevant content. The magic lies behind the definition of "relevant". As Bharat puts it, "As with Google's Web ranking, relevance is determined by information retrieval techniques that look at the distribution of words in the article and



Bill literally receives four million pieces of e-mail per day, most of it spam

Steve Ballmer, Microsoft Chief Executive on Bill Gates



surrounding pages on the Web. If the article matches the query well it is deemed relevant and gets a high score. Other factors include the importance of the source, timeliness of the article, and importance of the news story, relative to other stories in the news currently."

He created Google News out of frustration; he says that the task of fishing for news amidst the Web's endless flow of information was very tiring. The Bangalorean, who did his Ph.D. in Computer Science from Georgia Tech in 1996, says he wrote for his campus newspaper during his B.Tech days at IIT-Madras. Bharat is passionate about journalism, as a news junkie, he had also developed an interactive, newspaper powered by Java in 1994. The Krakatoa Chronicle, as he called it, was able to tailor content according to users taste: it would, for example note that you spend a lot of time reading on sports, the Chronicle would remember that, and the next day the newspaper would look different. "In a second life, I would like to be a journalist," he has once been quoted.

The Google centre at Bangalore will mirror Google's other offices. It will undertake projects in data mining, data warehousing, business intelligence and knowledge management.

TREND > SEARCH TOOLS FOR THE DESKTOP

Google On Your Desktop

What would your life be without a search engine? Google has become a verb, keywords your mantra.

Now think of how cool it would be to extend that power to information sitting on your own computer, or on your local network. That thesis you were working on? Can't remember the name but it contained "plate tectonics" in the body... Wouldn't it be great if you could type in a few words, press [Enter] and after an eternity that spans milliseconds, ta-da—your document right in front of you, like magic!

It would indeed be great and the technology is here: save from hiding under a rock, you know about Google Desktop, you have probably given it a whirl (you should!). It's Google on your desktop, just like the name says but it is beta software, thus has a limited range of files which it can index. We will forgive it its growing pains and look elsewhere, for desktop search clients have mushroomed: Copernic Desktop Search, Filehand, blinkx, dtSearch, dowsr, and X1 to name the most popular. Some of these are free, others not (X1 will put you back US \$99 while dtSearch demands US \$199).

Filehand, dtSearch, Copernic and X1 are all little more than indexing services; Dowsr is designed as a research tool which maintains a local database of online search queries. blinkx meanwhile, mixes it all up—it essentially spiders the Internet and your local disk and links relevant content to "keywords". Received an e-mail with "Sachin Tendulkar" in the body? blinkx will provide relevant online links (complete with excerpts) plus head to your hard drive to find that essay you wrote on the maestro or that video clip of his trademark straight drive. Its "Smart Folder" feature is also worth mentioning-tag a